

THE FLYING FISH

Volans



SIZE RANKING 76

BRIGHTEST STARS Beta (β) 3.8, Gamma (γ) 3.8

GENITIVE Volantis

ABBREVIATION Vol

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM January–March

FULLY VISIBLE 14°N–90°S



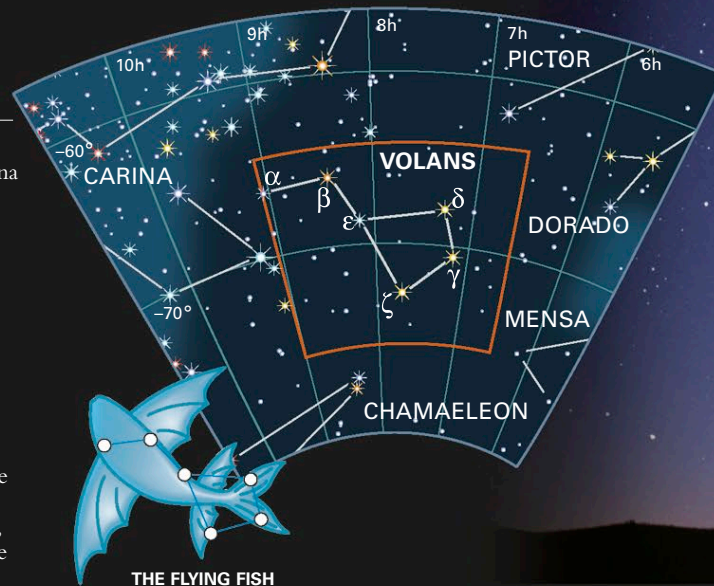
This small and faint constellation of the southern sky between Carina and the Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) was introduced in the late 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see p.416). It represents the tropical fish that uses its outstretched fins as wings to glide through the air.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Although it lies on the edge of the Milky Way, Volans is surprisingly bereft of deep-sky objects. It does, however, contain two good double stars, one of them being

4th-magnitude Gamma (γ) Volantis, which is jointly the brightest star in the constellation. This orange star has a yellow companion of 6th magnitude. They form a beautiful double when viewed through a small telescope.

Epsilon (ε) Volantis is another interesting double, although it is not as colorful as Gamma. Its components, which are of 4th and 7th magnitudes, can be detected readily through a small telescope.



THE FLYING FISH

FISH IN FLIGHT

The Flying Fish leaps into the evening sky above the eastern horizon. Beneath it here are the Milky Way and the stars of Carina and Vela, with the False Cross at left.

THE TABLE MOUNTAIN

Mensa



SIZE RANKING 75

BRIGHTEST STAR Alpha (α) 5.1

GENITIVE Mensae

ABBREVIATION Men

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM December–February

FULLY VISIBLE 5°N–90°S



The French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see panel, right) introduced this constellation. It commemorates Table Mountain near the modern Cape Town, South Africa, which is close to where he set up his observatory. When viewing the wispy appearance of the Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) in Mensa, de Lacaille may have recalled the clouds sometimes seen over the real Table Mountain. It is the only constellation that de Lacaille did not name after a scientific or artistic tool.

Mensa is the faintest of all 88 constellations, and its brightest star, Alpha (α) Mensae, is of only 5th magnitude. Its main point of interest is that part of the Large Magellanic Cloud overlaps into it from neighboring Dorado. Other than this cloud, there is nothing to attract the casual observer to this small constellation of the south polar region of the sky.

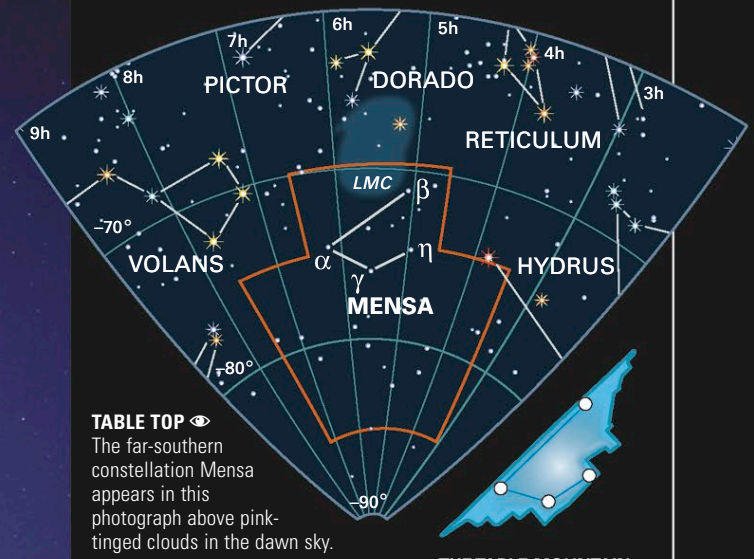
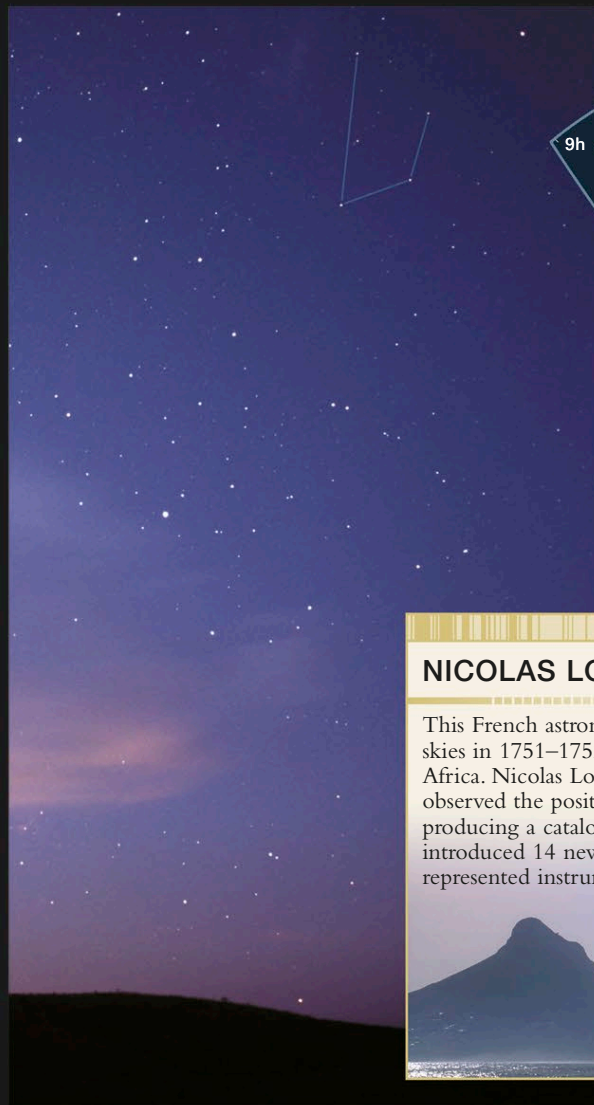


TABLE TOP

The far-southern constellation Mensa appears in this photograph above pink-tinged clouds in the dawn sky.

THE TABLE MOUNTAIN

NICOLAS LOUIS DE LACAILLE

This French astronomer charted the southern skies in 1751–1752 from Cape Town, South Africa. Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (1713–1762) observed the positions of nearly 10,000 stars, producing a catalog and star chart on which he introduced 14 new constellations. Most of these represented instruments of the arts and sciences.



SOUTHERN VIEWPOINT

Lacaille observed the stars from near Table Mountain, which is covered by an attractive “tablecloth” of clouds in this photograph.